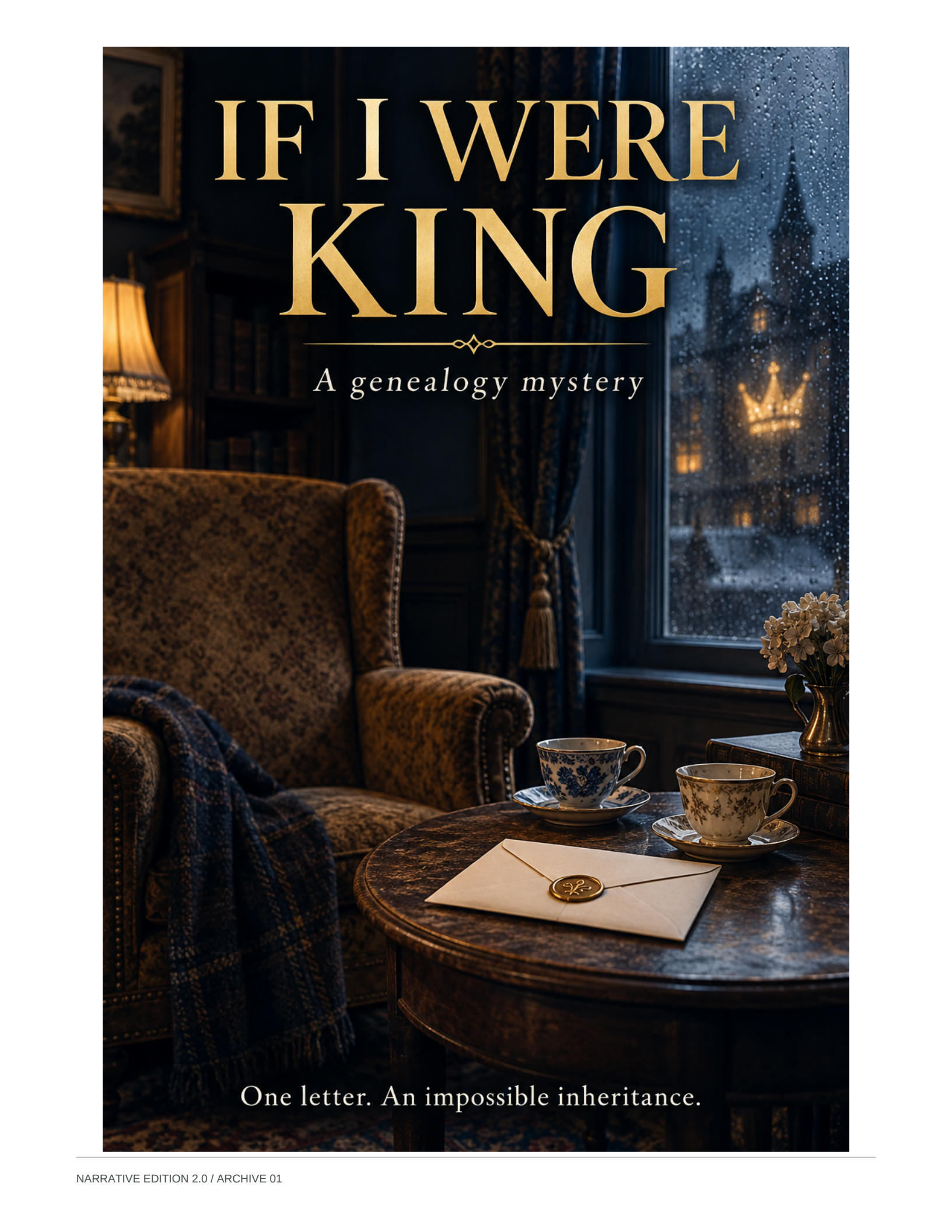




IF I WERE KING

A genealogy mystery

One letter. An impossible inheritance.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The unused cup

Before the opening brief

Daniel Wren put out two cups before remembering that he needed one. He left the second on the table. Taking it back to the shelf had become a small correction he could not always bear to make.

The letter from Veyr occupied Margaret's place.

He had read his own name in it several times. Daniel Wren, retired railway clerk. A man whose days had become quiet enough that the arrival of any post gave them a shape. The letter described a place in a succession. It did not offer the simple explanation for his life that he found himself wanting from it.

When Orme presented his declaration, Daniel listened longer than he might have listened to another man. Orme spoke as though there were still important tasks for him to perform, and as though experience at a railway desk might prepare him to do them well.

"You are accustomed to responsibility," Orme said.

Daniel looked at the two cups. "Some kinds."

Orme did not ask about the second. He put the paper where Daniel could sign it.

There was comfort in being given a line to complete. Daniel had spent a working life understanding which forms had to precede which decisions. The private declaration looked like another gate a sensible man should pass through without making trouble.

He reached for the pen, then drew the official letter nearer instead. Its warning about agents and authority was less flattering than Orme's account of him. It also had a seal and a reference he could check.

"I should like to read the earlier papers."

"Of course. There is the deadline to consider."

Daniel felt the pressure at once: asking to understand could be made to sound like refusing to act. He had not expected the possibility of a crown to resemble an awkward afternoon over a form.

"Then I ought to begin reading," he said.

Orme waited. Daniel had to resist filling the silence with an apology.

The second cup remained on the table after the papers were opened. Daniel could not ask Margaret whether the news would have amused or troubled her. He could look at the records of both families and refuse, for the moment, to let a stranger decide which of them mattered.

The letter calls him an heir.

Elmsreach, Massachusetts, and the fictional Kingdom of Veyr / April 1928

Since Margaret died, Daniel Wren has kept two cups on the kitchen shelf and used only one. He is sixty-two, a retired railway clerk, and has never been to Veyr. Until last week, he had scarcely heard of it.

Now a letter bearing the kingdom's seal says he is second in line for its vacant throne. A private representative has attached a declaration for his signature. Daniel wants someone to examine the papers before he answers.

He gives you the royal dossier and an old family box. The story they tell must be reconstructed: what makes his claim possible, who comes before him, and what the declaration would actually assert.

Your commission: Verify the notice, reconstruct the two relevant family branches, identify the first heir, rank Daniel correctly, and advise whether the attached declaration is supported by the evidence.

Start: Read K01, K02 and K03. Then use the archive catalog to choose a record that could answer your next question.

Case boundaries: Veyr, its monarchy, settlement and institutions are invented. Apply K03 exactly; no external succession law is needed. K18 defines the independently checked limits of this case. There are no hidden living branches, secret amendments or unprovided renunciations.

Complete your final report on page 25 before opening the separate solution. All people, places, institutions and records are fictional. Evidence pages are readable typeset facsimiles or selected-field transcriptions, not authentic scans.

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Archive catalog

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READ FIRST

Read the people. Test the papers.

Print the Player PDF in full. This edition contains 29 pages, including its cover and interleaved story. Use US Letter, portrait, actual size / 100%; on A4, use Fit. Grayscale is sufficient. Single-sided lets you spread the records out; duplex uses the long edge. Keep the separate hints and sealed solution away from the player stack.

Follow the printed archive folios. Existing page references mean the numbers labeled ARCHIVE in the footers, which remain stable. New story leaves use S0-S3. They make the PDF positions different from the archive numbers. Use the bookmarks or clickable catalog to find a page on screen.

Begin with the opening scene and brief. Read K01-K03 and choose your next record through archive folio 3. Each later scene names the records to read first. In a nonlinear search, return to that scene after you have examined its records; scene order does not prove a connection.

Let the records carry the proof. The new scenes dramatize the people around these papers. They are fictional narrative, not additional archival exhibits. A character can be mistaken. Names, dates, parents, addresses, source references, and the supplied rules establish the case; sympathy does not.

Make your case. Use archive folios 23-25. Cite exhibit codes and exact fields, test alternatives, and leave unsupported matters open. Everyone investigates; no host, internet, cutting, or outside research is required. Use hints only when needed; open the solution after answering all final questions.

The case includes bereavement, a reported childhood death, and family separation. Apply the invented settlement in K03 and the case bounds in K18.

The royal notice

18 April 1928

Veyrian Legation / dispatch V-228 / signed M. Sorel

Addressee	Mr Daniel Wren, 18 Nettle Street, Elmsreach
Subject	Collateral succession under the Settlement of 1872
Position reported	Second in the present provisional order
Reason for contact	Identification and documentary confirmation
Response deadline	30 April 1928
Official signatory	Marta Sorel, Legation Secretary

The death of Queen Adelise without a surviving descendant brings the collateral remainder into operation. The registered search presently places you second. Your present surname does not by itself defeat a claim. Neither this notice nor an agent's enclosure installs a sovereign.

Please return through the Legation any relevant birth, marriage or family correspondence. You may verify this dispatch independently by its number. Mr Julian Orme is a private representative; his forms are not themselves instruments of the Crown.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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The unsigned declaration

Enclosed 19 April 1928

Julian Orme & Co. / proposed declaration B

I, Daniel Wren, state that, so far as the records in my possession establish, no child or other descendant of Margaret Wren, born Hale, survives. I authorize Mr Julian Orme to present this statement as evidence that the senior remainder has failed.

I further authorize him to pursue my admission as the next eligible claimant and to receive all correspondence in that matter until the proceedings conclude.

Signature	UNSIGNED
Cover instruction	Sign before requesting the remaining senior-line papers
Prepared by	Julian Orme & Co.
Official registry seal	None

This is proposed wording, not a signed statement or an established finding. Decide whether its factual assertion is supported after reviewing the evidence.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

The succession settlement

Settlement: 12 July 1872 / certified extract: 3 April 1928

Veyrian Registry of State / articles 4-9

Article 4. Upon the extinction of the present reigning Deren line, the Crown passes first to the qualifying descendants of Princess Helena Arden, and only after that entire branch is exhausted to the qualifying descendants of her younger brother Prince Otto Arden.

Articles 5-6. Within each branch, the eldest child and that child's descendants precede a younger child and that child's descendants. A deceased ancestor is represented by the ancestor's qualifying descendants. Sex does not alter this order. The younger branch does not move ahead merely because one of its members is older or a generation nearer the root.

Article 7. Marriage neither gives a spouse the other spouse's descent nor extinguishes a descendant's own claim. A change of surname, foster placement or adoption does not extinguish descent for this Settlement. It may require additional identity evidence.

Articles 8-9. Renunciation must be an adult claimant's signed instrument entered in the Registry. It is effective only for the named signer unless an express registered provision says otherwise. An agent's assertion, absence from the country or an unsigned draft is not renunciation.

These are fictional rules, stipulated valid for the game. K18 supplies the checked branch and registry bounds. Do not import the law of a real monarchy.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

The elder remainder

Certified 6 April 1928

Veyrian dynastic register / Helena branch / entries H-1 to H-3

H-1	Princess Helena Arden, born 4 February 1790; died 8 August 1860
H-2	Louise Arden, born 12 March 1815; daughter of Helena Arden and Charles Meret
Louise's marriage	Anton Vale, 7 June 1839
H-3	Celia Vale, born 11 August 1842 in Linden, Veyr
H-3 parents	Anton Vale and Louise Vale, born Arden
Later annotation	Celia left for the United States in 1863; residence correspondence: Elmsreach

The relationship entries above are certified extracts from the associated family registers. Later identities and descendants must be established from the receiving country's records. Louise died 2 September 1878.

This register establishes a branch, not the identity of every person subsequently using the surname Vale.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

A marriage in Elmsreach

17 June 1866

St Mark's, Elmsreach / marriage register / M-36

Groom	Thomas Hale, cabinetmaker, aged 28
Bride	Celia Vale, seamstress, aged 23
Bride's birth	11 August 1842 / Linden, Veyr
Bride's parents	Anton Vale and Louise Arden
Bride's arrival year	1863, as supplied for the entry
Home after marriage	18 Nettle Street, Elmsreach
Witnesses	Edmund Wren and Ellen Wren

Names, birth particulars and parents entered at the time of the marriage. The record supplies the particulars given by the parties, not a general immigration history.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

Margaret's family entries

Birth: 4 May 1868 / marriage: 14 September 1889

St Mark's / birth B-69 and marriage M-164

Birth B-69

Child	Margaret Hale
Born	4 May 1868 / Elmsreach
Parents	Thomas Hale and Celia Hale, formerly Vale
Residence	18 Nettle Street

Marriage M-164

Bride	Margaret Hale, aged 21
Groom	Daniel Wren, aged 24, railway clerk
Bride's parents	Thomas Hale and Celia Vale
Groom's parents	Edmund Wren and Ellen Price
Marriage date	14 September 1889

A marriage connects spouses. It does not make their separate ancestral branches identical.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

The younger remainder

Certified 6 April 1928

Veyrian dynastic register / Otto branch / entries O-1 to O-3

O-1	Prince Otto Arden, born 9 November 1793; died 20 June 1859
O-2	Frederick Arden, born 7 July 1818; son of Otto Arden and Sofia Veidt
Frederick's marriage	Agnes Wren, 3 April 1838
O-3	Edmund Arden, born 2 January 1840 in Linden, Veyr
O-3 parents	Frederick Arden and Agnes Arden, born Wren
Later annotation	Edmund emigrated in 1862; correspondence filed under Wren in Elmsreach

Frederick died 16 March 1870. These entries certify the direct relationships stated; the later surname must be traced through the associated identity papers.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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The Arden-Wren name record

12 December 1863

Elmsreach civil papers / certified name record NC-18

Name before change	Edmund Arden
Name entered for future use	Edmund Wren
Birth	2 January 1840 / Linden, Veyr
Parents	Frederick Arden and Agnes Wren
Residence	7 Station Road, Elmsreach
Spouse	Ellen Price
Effective date	12 December 1863
Filed reference	NC-18

This entry identifies one person under the two recorded surnames. It contains no statement relinquishing a dynastic claim.

An invented civil document, not a facsimile of a specific jurisdiction's name-change procedure. Apply its stated identity facts within the game.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

Daniel's birth and Margaret's death

Birth: 21 May 1865 / death: 9 February 1926

Elmsreach family records / B-41 and D-52

Birth B-41

Child	Daniel Wren
Born	21 May 1865 / Elmsreach
Father	Edmund Wren, formerly Arden / NC-18
Mother	Ellen Wren, formerly Price
Residence	7 Station Road

Death D-52

Deceased	Margaret Wren, formerly Hale
Death	9 February 1926 / Elmsreach
Birth	4 May 1868
Spouse; informant	Daniel Wren, railway clerk
Parents	Thomas Hale and Celia Vale

These records establish Daniel's separate parentage and Margaret's death. They do not certify the complete history of the couple's children.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

THE STORY CONTINUES

A life described as a branch

After K03-K09

Daniel knew how strange a familiar name could look in an unfamiliar column. Margaret was his wife. In the papers from Veyr, she was also a point in a line of descent, connected backward through names he had never needed to compare this carefully.

The settlement did not remember their marriage as he did. It needed birth order, parentage, survival, and the way a branch was to be followed. A spouse could stand beside someone through a life without becoming that person's descendant. The distinction was plain in the rule and oddly painful at the table.

"The papers have no feeling for it," he said.

Orme arranged a page squarely against another. "They are intended to bring certainty."

Daniel wondered how often he himself had sounded like that behind a counter. He had not always meant to be unkind. A man could become attached to a procedure because it allowed him to finish a day without carrying every applicant's life home.

He read the names again. A marriage changed one surname. A registered change altered another. Neither entry gave permission to turn the people into strangers merely because a later record called them something else.

Orme asked whether the family information was now sufficient for the declaration.

"Sufficient for which sentence?" Daniel asked.

The question surprised him. Until that morning he had been treating the signature as a single act. The paper contained separate assertions. Each would have to be true, not merely convenient to sign together.

Orme's answer was practiced. He could explain the orderly course the declaration would allow. He was less eager to leave a course open that it might obstruct.

Daniel set the unsigned paper aside. Margaret's family could not be reduced to the part that served his own position. Nor could his father's former surname be treated as the end of a line merely because the name was no longer used at home.

He put two headings on a clean sheet. Two branches. Under each, space for the connections the actual documents could prove.

The child's birth

10 October 1891

St Mark's, Elmsreach / birth entry B-308

Child	Anna Wren
Born	10 October 1891 / Elmsreach
Father	Daniel Wren, railway clerk
Mother	Margaret Wren, formerly Hale
Residence	18 Nettle Street
Baptism	8 November 1891
Sponsors	Celia Hale and Edmund Wren

Entry made in the ordinary sequence of the family register. No death annotation appears on this birth entry.

The absence of a death annotation is not itself proof of survival. Look for affirmative later records.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

The temporary care register

Admitted 10 February 1892 / transferred 4 April 1892

Elmsreach Family Home / district E / child E-214

Child	Anna Wren
Birth date	10 October 1891
Parents	Daniel Wren and Margaret Wren, formerly Hale
Family address	18 Nettle Street
Reason entered	Temporary care during mother's serious illness
District and number	E-214
Status at transfer	Alive; transferred 4 April 1892
Receiving placement	Family placement F-37 / George and Harriet Alder

Reference prefixes identify separate district registers. Do not omit the letter when requesting a record. Placement paperwork is filed by F reference.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

The notice in Daniel's box

19 March 1892

Family correspondence / Home notice addressed to Daniel Wren

To Mr Daniel Wren, 18 Nettle Street: We regret to advise you that the child Anna died yesterday. We are making the necessary arrangements. Kindly quote 214 in any inquiry. Superintendent's office.

Name supplied on notice	Anna
Date of death implied	18 March 1892
Reference printed	214
Surname, birth date and district	Not supplied
Daniel's pencil note	Our Anna. Margaret must be told gently.

The envelope and note explain what Daniel was told and understood. The notice must still be matched to the underlying child record.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

The underlying death entry

18 March 1892

West district child register / W-214; civil death D-107

Child	Anna Ward
Birth	3 January 1891
Death	18 March 1892
Age	1 year
Parents	James Ward and Helen Ward, formerly Booth
Family address	2 Church Lane, West district
Home reference	W-214
Civil death reference	D-107
Notice instruction	Send to parents at family address above

This death entry and its original notice instruction refer to the Ward child. The civil entry is filed under Ward. No alteration to Wren appears in the entry.

The supplied records do not identify who misaddressed or abbreviated the notice later found in Daniel's box.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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THE STORY CONTINUES

The notice he believed

After K10-K13

Daniel recognized his own penciled words before he finished reading the notice.

Our Anna. Margaret must be told gently.

He had once thought the difficult part was how to carry the news from a piece of paper to his wife. The handwriting preserved that effort. It did not show him checking whether the paper identified their child.

For a moment the old urgency returned so completely that he wanted to put the notice face down. He could not bear to make the comparison. He could not bear the thought of declining to make it again.

"You were given an account," Orme said.

Daniel looked up. It sounded like absolution offered before he knew what had gone wrong.

"I made it into ours."

That was the part his pencil established. It did not establish who sent the notice to the wrong place, whether anyone intended harm, or what every institution had known.

Those would be tempting stories to build around the shame he now felt. The supplied papers had more limited things to say.

The birth entry, care record, and death registration had fields the notice lacked. Daniel moved them close enough to compare without lifting his eyes far from the table.

He thought of Margaret's illness as something they had lived through, not as permission for an office to stop looking carefully at their child. He also thought of all the forms on which he had once accepted a familiar number before checking the rest of the line.

"No one can be expected to know everything," Orme said.

"No," Daniel answered. "But now I have these."

Hope was frightening enough that he would not name it yet. A mismatch was a reason to investigate, not a promise that every loss would be reversed. Somewhere beyond these pages there might be another record, another name, another person who had built an entire life without his questions in it.

He would not use that possibility to excuse himself. He would not let fear of being mistaken keep him from following it.

The Alder placement papers

4 April 1892 to 18 September 1894

Family placement F-37 / adoption-name entry A-77

Child received alive	Anna Wren
Birth date copied and checked	10 October 1891
Sending reference	Elmsreach Family Home / E-214
Received by	George Alder and Harriet Alder, formerly Reed
Placement reference	F-37 / 4 April 1892
Later name entry	A-77 / 18 September 1894
Name before entry A-77	Anna Wren
Name after entry A-77	Irene Alder

The later order records adoption by George and Harriet Alder. Its application describes the birth parents as untraced. That description does not alter the original E-214 identity or the birth date.

The adoption is stipulated valid in this fictional case. K03 supplies its effect on the Veyrian succession. No general claim about adoption law is intended.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

A marriage under another name

14 November 1914

St Luke's, Cedarwick / marriage entry M-77

Bride	Irene Alder
Age; birth date	23; 10 October 1891
Bride's parents as recorded	George Alder and Harriet Reed
Identity document produced	Adoption-name entry A-77; copy attached
Groom	Samuel Moss, teacher, aged 25
Bride's occupation	Teacher
Intended residence	9 School Lane, Cedarwick
Marriage date	14 November 1914

The bride signs Irene Alder. The entry identifies the parents named in her adoption papers; it does not replace the birth-parent information in the earlier record chain.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

A school's reply

12 April 1928

Cedar House School / staff identity verification / S-41

Staff member	Irene Moss, previously Irene Alder
Birth date held	10 October 1891
Marital record held	St Luke's M-77 / Samuel Moss
Employment	Teacher, continuously on staff since September 1915
Home	9 School Lane, Cedarwick
Current verification	Present at the school and interviewed on 12 April 1928
Signed	Irene Moss; witnessed by headmistress Anne Bury

The dates, prior name and marriage reference above were compared with the documents on file. The school can confirm the staff member's identity and presence, not adjudicate a foreign succession.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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A memorandum from the private office

16 April 1928

Julian Orme & Co. / retained office copy / J-19

To the senior clerk: Secure Mr Wren's declaration before sending him the Alder papers. The school reply has already located the woman. Do not describe the return under A-77 as a living-child finding in correspondence with him.

Our instruction is to advance the younger remainder. A male claimant who has already signed the absence-of-issue statement will be simpler to present. Adoption can be emphasized in the covering argument; do not enclose the full text of article 7 unless the Legation requests it.

Initials	J.O.
Associated file	Declaration B / client Daniel Wren
Distribution	Office copy; not a Legation instruction

This memorandum supports a finding about this office's proposed handling of evidence. It is not proof that the Legation or school participated in the plan.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)

Independent registry verification

22 April 1928

Veyrian Registry and Legation / reply to Daniel Wren / V-241

Dispatch verified	V-228, issued 18 April 1928 by Marta Sorel
Private representative	Julian Orme has no authority to amend the Settlement
Reigning Deren line	Queen Adelise died 2 April 1928; no surviving descendant
Helena line checked	Helena -> Louise -> Celia -> Margaret; ancestors all deceased
Possible continuation	The child recorded in B-308; identity and survival require the supplied chain
Otto line checked	Otto -> Frederick -> Edmund -> Daniel; ancestors deceased
Other qualifying living people	None besides Daniel and the possible B-308 child; no descendants of that child
Registered renunciations relevant here	None
Applicable text	Articles 4-9 as reproduced in K03; no intervening amendment

The completeness and authenticity of this reply are stipulated case facts. It bounds the investigation; the player must still connect the people and apply the rules. It does not supply the missing child's present name.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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THE STORY CONTINUES

The convenient version

After K14-K18

By the time Daniel reached the private office memorandum, he had learned to distrust the relief of a quick answer. Even so, the instruction to secure his declaration before the other papers arrived made him feel foolish in a fresh way.

Orme had offered a path on which Daniel could remain the central person. The missing information would have made that path harder to control.

"You wanted me to sign what your own office had reason to question," Daniel said.

Orme began to speak of complications. He spoke as a man who could imagine the work ahead: competing papers, correspondence, an inconvenient person with an independent life. Daniel could understand an administrator preferring one manageable claimant. Understanding made the act more ordinary, not less disturbing.

"You called it helping me."

"I was trying to obtain a clear result."

Daniel looked down at the teacher's reply. A woman had continued living and working while other people considered whether her existence should complicate their arrangements. She was not a blank space waiting to improve his story.

The surviving records had to be linked: birth, care entry, transfer, change of name, marriage, present identity. Then the settlement had to be applied. Daniel could not move someone up the order because he wanted a reunion, any more than Orme could move someone out of it for convenience.

He placed the official correspondence apart from Orme's private papers. "These will go to the legation directly."

He had not yet written the account. He still needed to set it out so another reader could test each connection. That work felt more like responsibility than the title had.

The unused cup caught his eye. He had been imagining what the news could give him: a purpose, a name in a foreign court, perhaps an answer to a grief he had stopped questioning. Now there was another person's right to hear the truth and decide what contact she wanted.

Daniel put the pen beside a clean sheet. The next signature would need to follow an account he could support.

Two branches. One order.

Trace each link from the named remainder root to a living person. A spouse can connect two families without merging their places in the order.

Helena branch / generations, names, dates and citations

Otto branch / generations, names, dates and citations

Surname changes and identity links / records that establish them

Apply the settlement / branch priority, adoption, sex and renunciation

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Follow the child through the references.

Write each record number with its prefix. Separate what a parent was told from what a record establishes.

Birth, care entry and notice / agreements and discrepancies

The death entry / identity fields and district

Placement, later name, marriage and present identity

The declaration / supported facts, contrary evidence and private-office conduct

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What should Daniel answer?

Summarize here; put supporting details on your working sheets.

1. Is the official notice genuine within the case, and what does it actually authorize?

2. Who ranks first, and how does that person connect to the elder branch? Cite the identity chain.

3. Why does Daniel qualify, and why is he second despite being older than the first heir?

4. What happened to the child in the old notice? Is the proposed declaration supportable?

5. What does the private memorandum establish, what remains uncertain, and what should Daniel do next?

[Return to archive catalog](#)